

THE PM INTERVIEW ANSWER GUIDE · PRODUCT SENSE, ESTIMATION, THE CLOSE

He Got the Offer. Here's the Difference.

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1 Ask who it's for before what it does

When they ask you to improve a product or build one from scratch, the interviewer is testing whether you think like an owner. Who is this for. What problem are they living with. How would you know you fixed it.

The answer that ends it: *"I'd just add the features users keep asking for."* That tells them you'd build whatever is loudest, for whoever shouts. Features are the last thing a strong candidate talks about, not the first.

EXAMPLE

"First: who's this for, and what does success look like? Then I'll prioritize."

2 Prioritize out loud, with the trade-off

Once you've named the user and the goal, rank your ideas in the open and say what you're giving up. Interviewers can't score reasoning they can't hear. "I'd build all three" is a refusal to choose. Choosing is the job.

Name your measure before your winner: if success is activation, the onboarding fix beats the new feature, and you should be able to say why in one breath.

EXAMPLE

"I'd start with the onboarding fix over the new feature. Activation is our number. Most users drop before they ever reach the feature. And here's how I'd check in the first 30 days."

3 Break it apart before you touch a number

Nobody in that room cares whether the true answer is 6 million or 8 million. They care whether you can take a question with no edges and give it structure before you give it a number.

The answer that ends it: *"Uh... probably a few million? I'm not really sure."* A guess with no layers gives the interviewer nothing to follow and nothing to hire. Write the layers down first, then work them top down, out loud, with a reason for every number. Like this:

How many cups of coffee are sold in New York City today?

People in NYC: about 8 million

- Share who drink coffee on a given day: say half $\rightarrow 8M \times 50\% = 4M$ drinkers
- Cups per drinker: about 1.5 $\rightarrow 4M \times 1.5 = 6M$ cups
- Add commuters and visitors who buy in the city: + about 1M

≈ 7 million cups today

4 Check your number before you sit down

A strong estimation answer doesn't end at the number. It ends with the check. Say the figure, say which assumption you're least sure of, and say how you'd verify it if this were your job. That last move is the one that sounds like a PM instead of a student.

If they push back, don't start over. Change the one assumption you're least sure of, out loud, and rerun the math from that layer down.

EXAMPLE

"Let me break it apart: market, segments, frequency. Here's my number, and here's how I'd check it."

5 End the interview like you want the job

"Do you have any questions for us?" is the last scored answer of the interview. Most candidates spend it on perks or throw it away completely.

The answer that ends it: *"No, I don't have any questions."* You just told them you're not curious about the role you're asking them to give you. Ask the question that makes them picture you in the seat. Then follow it with the one that shows you want to win in it, not just land it.

EXAMPLE

"What does success in this role look like in the first 90 days?"

"And what separates the PMs who succeed here from the ones who don't?"

6 Practice on these three

Set a timer for 15 minutes and answer all three out loud, in order. Record it on your phone.

"How would you improve the app you use most?" "How many cups of coffee are sold in New York City today?" "Do you have any questions for us?"

Play it back. Every time you name a feature before a user, guess before a layer, or end with no question, mark it. Then run the checklist below.

Score every answer

Use this checklist after each practice run:

- ☐ Did I ask who it's for before naming a feature?
- ☐ Did I say what success looks like before I prioritized?
- ☐ Did I break the estimate into layers before any math?
- ☐ Did I give a reason for every number I used?
- ☐ Did I state my final number and how I'd check it?
- ☐ Did I end with a real question about the role?
- ☐ Did I sound like I already work there?